

Lobbying Dossier: Establishment of the Digital Euro

Procedure 2023/0212(COD) – 1,242 amendments parsed across 4 amendment packages, 438 disclosed lobbying meetings, 272 organisations

Section 1 – The Lobbying Landscape

The digital euro proposal attracted lobbying activity from 272 organisations across 438 total meetings registered in the EU transparency system. Of these, 126 meetings were held directly with Commissioners, 53 of which contained substantive notes on topics discussed. All 8 policy themes defined for this analysis recorded at least some lobbying activity at Commission level.

The overwhelming majority of active organisations represent commercial interests. Among the top 30 organisations by meeting count, non-commercial actors include Positive Money Europe (10 meetings, lobbying on governance and oversight), the Bureau Européen des Unions de Consommateurs – BEUC (8 meetings, lobbying on privacy and data protection), Finance Watch (6 meetings, no theme attribution recorded), and the ECB (6 meetings, no commercial interest). The remaining organisations in the top 30 represent banks, payment processors, industry associations, or commercial payment infrastructure providers.

The two most-met organisations are Deutsche Bank AG and Mastercard Europe, each with 19 recorded meetings. EuroCommerce follows with 13, Amazon Europe Core SARL and Fédération bancaire française each with 11, and Asociación Española de Banca with 11. DIGITALEUROPE, European Payment Institutions Federation, Banco Santander, and Positive Money Europe each had 10 meetings.

By lobbying density, innovation and competition in payments is by far the most-engaged theme at Commission level, with 20 commission meetings, 22 total meetings, and 19 active organisations. Interoperability and cross-border payments recorded 9 commission meetings across 7 organisations. Cost recovery and funding model saw 6 commission meetings with 6 active organisations, followed by limits on holdings and remuneration (5 commission meetings, 4 organisations) and legal tender status and mandatory acceptance (4 commission meetings, 4 organisations). By contrast, offline functionality and accessibility – which attracted 234 amendments, the second-highest of any theme – recorded zero commission meetings and no active organisations in the disclosed data.

Section 2 – Most-Lobbied Legislation Sections

Innovation and Competition in Payments (20 commission meetings, 19 organisations)

The legislation as proposed states that the digital euro will be “offered as a public digital means of payment, alongside the existing private digital means of payment, supporting a stronger and more competitive, efficient and innovative European retail payments market.” It explicitly positions the digital euro as designed to “facilitate the development of pan-European and interoperable retail payment solutions, including the full roll-out of instant payments.”

Among the 20 commission meetings on this theme, positions varied substantially. Amazon Pay “welcomed the digital euro and emphasised its importance for payment innovation.” Revolut “fully supports the digital euro as an opportunity for innovation.” EPI Company, by contrast,

“voiced concerns about the digital euro and advocated for a clear regulatory framework governing interoperability with private payment solutions like Wero.” BNP Paribas and Société Générale “presented the Wero wallet and outlined their position on the digital euro.” Commerzbank “expressed difficulty identifying valuable business cases for the digital euro, signalling scepticism about its utility for the private banking sector.” The Italian Banking Association “stressed the need for the digital euro to enhance the competitiveness of the EU payments market.” Mastercard engaged the Commission on this theme on at least three separate occasions, including meetings in May 2025 and February 2026.

Interoperability and Cross-Border Payments (9 commission meetings, 7 organisations)

The legislation requires that digital euro users have access to onboarding and strong customer authentication through the EU-wide European Digital Identity Wallet under Article 97 of PSD2. It positions the digital euro as part of the Commission’s strategy for EU open strategic autonomy and the international role of the euro, and mandates consistency with existing AML/CFT and data protection frameworks.

Organisations expressing positions on this theme include Mastercard Europe, which “advocated for interoperability between the digital euro and private payment solutions, with the Commissioner confirming open standards to enable this.” SIBS “stressed the importance of ensuring the digital euro’s interoperability with existing payment solutions, drawing on their experience with TIPS and instant payments.” EPI Company called for “a clear regulatory framework governing interoperability with private payment solutions like Wero.” Representatives described as associated with Poland argued that Poland’s “high share of digital payments makes inclusion in the digital euro essential, and called for a European payment ecosystem governed by strict, transparent rules.”

Cost Recovery and Funding Model (6 commission meetings, 6 organisations)

The legislation excerpts associated with this theme in the analysis contain primarily procedural and bibliographic content and do not describe concrete fee or cost-recovery rules. Lobbying positions on this theme nonetheless show active engagement. Die Deutsche Kreditwirtschaft “raised unresolved questions about the cost structure for implementing the digital euro.” EuroCommerce “argued for a competitive compensation model for merchants regarding digital euro costs, and supported a proportionate approach to legal tender obligations.” Mercadona “presented positions on the digital euro’s compensation model, inter-PSP fee structure, and offline functionality.” Nordic financial associations “stressed that the digital euro rollout should not be too costly.” EPIF “stressed the need to preserve the digital euro’s open funding design and foster innovation in the payments market.” Rabobank discussed the legislative process status with the Commission.

Limits on Holdings and Remuneration (5 commission meetings, 4 organisations)

The legislation establishes the digital euro as issued under the ECB’s monetary policy mandate (Articles 127–133 TFEU) with the explicit goal of maintaining financial stability, implying that holding limits will be among the regulatory tools deployed. The digital euro is defined as non-programmable and fully fungible. No concrete numerical holding limits are specified in the excerpts provided.

All three organisations recorded on this theme – Deutscher Sparkassen-und Giroverband (DSGV), Bundesverband deutscher Banken e.V. (GBIC), and separately GBIC again – met with Commissioner Dombrovskis. DSGV “stressed the importance of banks’ role in distributing the digital euro and the viability of the project, while receiving an update on the Eurogroup agreement on holding limits.” GBIC “presented their position on the digital euro proposal in the context of competitiveness and

simplification, with the Commissioner noting the Eurogroup agreement on an institutional approach to setting holding limits.”

Legal Tender Status and Mandatory Acceptance (4 commission meetings, 4 organisations)

The legislation grounds mandatory acceptance in the argument that without a digitally usable form of central bank money, “trust towards commercial bank money, and ultimately towards the euro itself” is at risk. The digital euro would carry legal tender status equivalent to banknotes and coins, implying that merchants and public bodies would be required to accept it.

Die Deutsche Kreditwirtschaft “emphasized that merchant acceptance is key and raised unresolved questions about the cost structure.” EuroCommerce “argued for a competitive compensation model for merchants regarding digital euro costs, and supported a proportionate approach to legal tender obligations.” SIBS and The European Digital Payments Industry Alliance also appear as active organisations on this theme in the lobbying data.

Section 3 – Most-Lobbied Amendments

Amendment 1036 (Article 17 – paragraph 5a, new) – 33 matching positions

Proposed by Auke Zijlstra (Shadow, PfiE), this amendment to Article 17 would insert a new paragraph requiring the ECB to develop, in cooperation with payment service providers, a methodology for monitoring and calculating the fee amounts referred to in paragraphs 2 and 3 of Article 17, with the requirement that this methodology “respect the principle of an open market economy with free competition, in accordance with Article 127(1) TFEU.”

Organisations with positions sharing thematic overlap with this amendment include, on cost recovery: Die Deutsche Kreditwirtschaft (unresolved questions about cost structure), Mercadona (inter-PSP fee structure and compensation model), Finance Denmark and Nordic associations (cost concerns), Rabobank, EuroCommerce (competitive compensation model), EPIF (open funding design), and SIBS (fee levels and architecture). On innovation and competition: Amazon Pay, Mastercard Europe, Revolut, Kraken/Payward, Intesa Sanpaolo, BNP Paribas, Associazione Bancaria Italiana, Worldpay, Deutsche Bank, Bundesverband der Deutschen Volksbanken und Raiffeisenbanken, EPI Company, GBIC, Commerzbank, and SIBS. On governance: Deutsche Bank, Coinbase, Mastercard Europe, GBIC, Crédit Agricole, and two Polish-associated representatives.

Amendment 414 (Recital 26a, new) – 31 matching positions

Proposed by Luděk Niedermayer, Dirk Gotink, and Martine Kemp, this amendment proposes inserting a recital stating that “the establishment of the digital euro should not disincentivise innovation or limit the capacity of the private sector to develop competitive and value-added payment solutions” and that “the design and governance of the digital euro should therefore promote technological neutrality and support a dynamic and innovative payments ecosystem.”

Organisations with positions sharing thematic overlap include DSGVO (twice, emphasising banks’ role as intermediaries), Revolut (twice, supporting digital euro while raising single market concerns), BVR (Wero wallet presentation), Deutsche Bank (banking sector competitiveness and intermediary role), and the full set of 19 active organisations in the innovation and competition theme. On

governance: Coinbase, Mastercard Europe (multiple meetings), Deutsche Bank, GBIC (twice), Crédit Agricole, and Polish-associated representatives.

Amendment 603 (Article 3 – paragraph 1) – 29 matching positions

Proposed by Fernando Navarrete Rojas (Rapporteur, EPP) and eight co-signatories including Markus Ferber, Stefan Berger, Daniel Caspary, Ralf Seekatz, Christophe Gomart, Lúcia Pereira, Isabel Benjumea Benjumea, and Antonio López-Istúriz White, this amendment to Article 3 paragraph 1 would make the online digital euro conditional, requiring evidence of at least one successful pilot project of a pan-European sovereign retail payment solution covering all euro area Member States before the online digital euro comes into effect. The Commission would be required to perform a market test by the last quarter of 2028 to assess whether such a pilot has taken place.

Organisations with positions sharing thematic overlap include Mercadona on offline functionality, and the full set of innovation and competition and governance-theme organisations. Notably, several of the companies whose commission meeting positions are recorded – EPI Company (Wero), BNP Paribas/Société Générale (Wero), BVR (Wero) – are themselves developing or participating in pan-European private payment initiatives that would be relevant to such a market test. The legislation as proposed does not contain a conditionality mechanism of this type; the amendment would introduce a new structural precondition not present in the original text. The reader is left to evaluate the juxtaposition.

Amendment 1145 and 1148 (Article 24a, new) – 30 matching positions each

Amendment 1145, proposed by Auke Zijlstra and Pierre Pimpe (Pfe), and Amendment 1148, proposed by Jussi Saramo, both propose inserting a new Article 24a. Amendment 1145 states: “The European Central Bank shall monitor and use technological developments for the purpose mentioned in Article 24a(2), including new technologies which are in particular designed to protect privacy, enhance data protection, security preparedness, resilience, and fraud detection and prevention.” Amendment 1148 states that the ECB “shall implement new technological developments in the digital euro infrastructure to improve inter alia privacy protection, preparedness and resilience, and introduce innovative functionalities, after assessing their purpose and costs.”

Organisations with positions on privacy themes include Finance Denmark (GDPR concerns and AML data processing tensions) and BEUC (consumer privacy, fraud protection, and AML safeguards). The remaining 28 matching positions derive from innovation and competition and governance theme overlap.

Section 4 – MEP Meeting Profiles

Fernando Navarrete Rojas (Rapporteur, EPP)

Navarrete Rojas recorded 106 meetings and proposed 73 amendments. His three most-met organisations were Banco Santander and BBVA (3 meetings each) and BNP Paribas, European Banking Federation, French Treasury, Deutsche Bank, Bizum, Bundesbank, and MERCADONA (2 meetings each). His amendments concentrate most heavily on limits on holdings and remuneration (29 amendments) and governance and oversight (24 amendments), followed by role of intermediaries (24) and offline functionality (18). His meetings concentrate most heavily on innovation and competition in payments (10 meetings) and interoperability (7 meetings), with 6 overlapping themes between his

meeting portfolio and his amendments: cost recovery, innovation and competition, interoperability, legal tender, limits on holdings, and privacy.

Damian Boeselager (Shadow, Greens/EFA)

Boeselager recorded 79 meetings and proposed 163 amendments – the highest amendment count among key MEPs. His most-met organisations include European Payment Institutions Federation (4 meetings), Positive Money and Positive Money Europe (3 meetings each), Deutsche Bank (3 meetings), Verbraucherzentrale Bundesverband (2), Giesecke+Devrient (2), European Environmental Bureau (2), and EPI Company (2). His amendments concentrate on role of intermediaries (45), privacy (44), governance (38), and offline functionality (35). His meetings concentrate on innovation and competition (10), cost recovery (5), and interoperability (5). Seven themes overlap between his meetings and his amendments.

Gilles Boyer (Shadow, Renew)

Boyer recorded 45 meetings and proposed 155 amendments. His most-met organisations include Fédération bancaire française (6 meetings), BNP Paribas (3 meetings), Finance Watch (2), BPCE (2), European Digital Payments Industry Alliance (2), American Express (2), Deutsche Bank (2), and Amazon Europe Core SARL (2). His amendments concentrate on governance (48), role of intermediaries (46), and cost recovery (28). His meetings concentrate heavily on innovation and competition in payments (16 meetings). Seven themes overlap between his meetings and his amendments.

Auke Zijlstra (Shadow, P/E)

Zijlstra recorded 12 meetings and proposed 108 amendments. His most-met organisations include Vereniging VNO-NCW (3 meetings), Vincens Consulting (2), and EuroCommerce (2). His amendments focus on governance (29), offline functionality (25), and privacy (18). His meetings recorded overlap on innovation and competition (3 meetings), interoperability (3 meetings), and legal tender (2 meetings). Three themes overlap between his meetings and his amendments. Zijlstra is the sole author of Amendment 1036 (the highest-density amendment by matching position count) and co-author of Amendment 1145.

Nikos Papandreu (Shadow, S&D)

Papandreu recorded 3 meetings – among the lowest of any key MEP – and proposed 171 amendments. His three meetings were with European Banking Federation, Intesa Sanpaolo, and Fédération bancaire française. His amendments are distributed across all 9 themes, with offline functionality (48) and governance (36) most prominent. Only 1 theme – innovation and competition – overlaps between his meetings and his amendment portfolio.

Section 5 – Limitations

No causal relationship between any lobbying contact and any legislative position can be established from this analysis; the data describe disclosed meetings and amendment texts, not decision-making processes or intent. The analysis covers only meetings disclosed in the EU Transparency Register and Commission meeting logs – informal contacts, phone calls, correspondence, and undisclosed interactions are not observable. Temporal ordering between meetings and amendments has not been verified: some commission meetings may have occurred after the relevant amendments were tabled,

meaning the sequence implied by co-occurrence cannot be assumed. Thematic matching between lobby positions and amendments is performed through keyword-based methods applied to the policy taxonomy; this approach may produce false positives where shared terminology does not reflect shared substantive concern, and may miss semantic connections expressed in different vocabulary.

This dossier was produced by an automated analysis pipeline (procedure 2023/0212(COD), analysis date 2026-03-30). Thematic matching and position summaries were generated with AI assistance and have not been independently verified against primary source documents.